

Photographs by HEMANT CHAWLA



Almost every suspect involved in recent bomb blasts comes from this town. What is it that makes Azamgarh the most common back story of radical Islam in India?

THE ANCESTRY OF HATE



■ By S. Prasannarajan in Azamgarh

Look around before you whisper it. Be afraid if the place appears in your permanent home address. Escape its drabness only to be awakened by a knock on the door—or a gunshot—in your most isolated, unguarded moment, when you are trapped in that space between faith and anger. It is a place where martyrdom can be booked in advance—or victimhood is a constant anticipation. It is where those who hear the call of the Book buy their one-way ticket to paradise from the nearest travel agent. It is where the terror of Islamic radicalism is a distant echo and the terrorist is an intimate loss. And its mythology continues to be co-authored by the god, the cop and the journalist. Azamgarh, the so-

called ancestral village of Indian jihad, multiplies in police records as the country has become the softest target for the new recruits into the bloodiest religious war of our times.

Almost every terrorist attack in India today has a back story in which Azamgarh is the first point of initiation. Mumbai, Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Delhi... and the killer's original postal code is invariably that of this town in eastern Uttar Pradesh. In the wake of the recent bomb attacks in Mehrauli, Delhi, and the arrest and killing of the alleged student terrorists from Jamia Millia, the notoriety of Azamgarh has become a page one, prime time national curiosity. Suddenly, the 300-km drive from Lucknow has become a passage to the provenance of hate. Overexcited punsters have even gone to the extent of calling it